

Integration Testing — HelixVPN nano-detail spec (Volume 8 · §11.4.169 type 2)

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Revision: 1 Last modified: 2026-06-26T12:00:00Z

Nano-detail expansion of [§5.2 of the Volume-8 overview](#). Integration (INT) is the **first layer where mocks are forbidden** (§11.4.27): every seam that touches real infrastructure is exercised against a *real* Postgres, a *real* Redis, and a *real* edge, booted **on-demand** through the `vasic-digital/containers` submodule (§11.4.76) running **rootless** (§11.4.161). This document fixes the INT surface, the on-demand-infra invariant, the no-log schema invariant, the captured evidence, the determinism contract, the acceptance gate, the paired §1.1 mutation, and concrete skeletons. Spec-only; unproven assumptions marked UNVERIFIED. Siblings: [unit.md](#) (mocks live there, not here), [e2e.md](#), [full-automation.md](#), [challenges.md](#), [helixqa.md](#).

Table of contents

- [1. Scope — the seams INT covers](#)
- [2. Harness — the containers submodule is the ONLY path](#)
- [3. Fixtures — real services, seeded data, zero mocks](#)
- [4. Evidence taxonomy — what an INT PASS captures](#)
- [5. Determinism — N-iteration identical evidence](#)
- [6. Acceptance gate — when INT blocks a release](#)
- [7. The paired §1.1 mutation \(anti-bluff proof\)](#)
- [8. Test skeletons](#)

- 9. Open decisions surfaced for QA
- Sources verified

1. Scope — the seams INT covers

INT owns every place where two real components meet over real infrastructure — the seams a unit test cannot reach without a mock (and a mock here is a §11.4.27 violation).

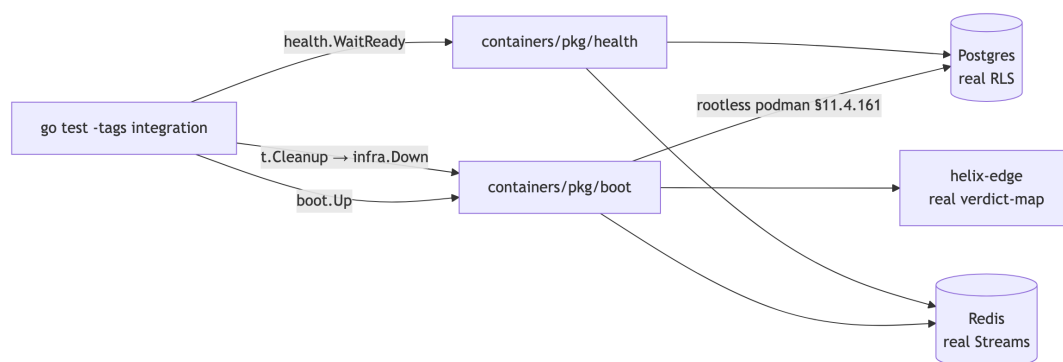
Seam	Components	The invariant proven (real infra)	Spec source
RLS multi-tenant isolation	svc-identity + Postgres	a tenant-B query under tenant-A's RLS role returns zero tenant-B rows	../v03-control-plane/data-model-ddl.md , ../v05-security/no-logging-as-code.md
Device enrollment end-to-end	svc-identity + svc-registry + svc-pki + Postgres	OIDC/anon token → device-generated WG keypair (private key never persisted server-side) → short-lived mTLS cert issued	../v05-security/identity-and-enrollment.md , ../v03-control-plane/svc-pki.md
Event backbone round-trip	svc-events + Redis Streams + svc-coordinator	publish on a Redis stream → coordinator consumer-group consume → minimal delta emitted; XAUTOCLAIM DLQ on a stuck consumer	../v03-control-plane/svc-events.md , ../v03-control-plane/reconciliation-flow.md
WatchNetworkMap server-stream	svc-coordinator + svc-policy + Postgres	snapshot + deltas; peers already policy-filtered (need-to-know); a new	../v03-control-plane/svc-coordinator.md , ../v03-control-plane/protobuf-spec.md

Seam	Components	The invariant proven (real infra)	Spec source
		enroll appears as a delta	
IPAM persistence (the allocation half)	svc-ipam + Postgres FOR UPDATE	a real allocation is durable, unique, and survives a reconnect (the <i>math</i> half is UNIT, unit.md §8.3)	../v03-control-plane/svc-ipam.md
No-log schema invariant	Postgres DDL + schema-lint	the live schema contains no durable per-flow / per-connection / per-packet table; only aggregate counters	../v05-security/no-logging-as-code.md
Policy compile → enforce (control half)	svc-policy + svc-coordinator + edge config	a compiled policy reaches the edge verdict-map config (the <i>packet</i> enforcement is E2E/SEC)	../v03-control-plane/svc-policy.md
API authz	svc-api (Gin/Connect-RPC) + svc-identity	a token scoped to tenant-A cannot mutate tenant-B; revoked token rejected	../v03-control-plane/svc-api.md

Boundary with E2E: INT proves the *control-plane seams* (a delta is emitted, a cert is issued, a row is isolated). The moment the assertion needs a **packet on a real tunnel** (reach an authorized LAN host, default-deny a SYN) it is E2E and uses the netns rig ([e2e.md](#)) — INT does not build tunnels.

2. Harness — the containers submodule is the ONLY path

Per §11.4.76 (containers-submodule mandate) + §11.4.161 (rootless), **all** containerised infra is booted through vasic-digital/containers (digital.vasic.containers, Go) via its pkg/boot / pkg/compose / pkg/health primitives. There is **no** docker/podman CLI anywhere in the INT harness; no sudo; no rootful Docker. This is the **on-demand-infra invariant**: make test (or go test -tags integration) boots Postgres + Redis (+ edge where needed) itself, runs against the real services, and tears them down — the developer never runs podman machine or docker compose up by hand.



- **Boot:** `boot.Up(ctx, boot.Spec{Postgres:true, Redis:true, Rootless:true})` returns an infra handle exposing DSNs/addresses. The `Rootless:true` field is the §11.4.161 binding — a rootful spec is rejected by the submodule on a platform that supports rootless.
- **Health:** `health.WaitReady(ctx, infra, health.Postgres)` blocks until the service answers a real probe (a `SELECT 1`, a Redis `PING`) — never a fixed sleep, which is a §11.4.107(3) loading-vs-ready confusion and a flake source.
- **Teardown:** `t.Cleanup(func(){ infra.Down(ctx) })` guarantees quiescence on every exit path (§11.4.14); an orphaned container after the test is a §11.4.14 violation the post-test sanity check FAILs on.
- **Missing capability ⇒ extend upstream:** if a needed lifecycle primitive is absent from containers, it is added by an upstream PR (§11.4.74), never reimplemented in-project with a raw podman call.

Invocation seam (Makefile, [overview §9](#)): `test: cargo test && go test -race ./helix-go/... && melos run test`. The integration build tag gates the boot so unit-only runs (pre-commit) do not pay the container cost; INT runs on the **pre-push** hook (§11.4.75 Layer-2).

3. Fixtures — real services, seeded data, zero mocks

Fixture	Real or mock	Notes
Postgres instance	real (booted via containers)	migrated to the production DDL (../v03-control-plane/data-model-ddl.md); RLS policies enabled
Redis instance	real	Streams + consumer groups; ephemeral (no persistence — the no-log posture)
edge process	real helix-edge build	for policy-enforce-config INT (not packet enforcement)
seed tenants/devices	real rows via the real API/store	seedTenant(db,"tenant-A","device-a1") — inserted through the same code path production uses
OIDC/anon tokens	real-shaped, test-issuer	a real token validation path; the issuer is a test key (a §11.4.10 bootstrap credential, outside test execution)
mocks	FORBIDDEN (§11.4.27)	any mock/stub/fake import in an INT test file FAILs CM-NO-FAKES-BEYOND-UNIT-TESTS

The seed data is inserted through the **production store interface**, not raw SQL back-doors, so the INT test exercises the real write path. The only permitted out-of-band setup is the §11.4.10 credential bootstrap (a .env test token), which is configuration, not test driving (§11.4.98).

4. Evidence taxonomy — what an INT PASS captures

Per §11.4.5/§11.4.69 an INT PASS cites a **captured artifact** whose shape the seam fixes — never a config-only / absence-of-error assertion (bluff-class B1/B2).

Seam	§11.4.69 evidence shape	Artifact path
RLS isolation	the captured rowset under each tenant's RLS role (A sees a1, not b1)	qa-results/int/rls_<ts>.json
enrollment	the issued cert chain + a log/DB scan proving zero private-key bytes	qa-results/int/enroll_<ts>/

Seam	§11.4.69 evidence shape	Artifact path
	persisted server-side (§11.4.10)	
event round-trip	the consumed-event transcript + emitted-delta JSON, with publish-ts→delta-ts timing	qa-results/int/events_<ts>.jsonl
WatchNetworkMap	the server-stream transcript: snapshot frame + the post-enroll delta frame, peers policy-filtered	qa-results/int/watch_<ts>.jsonl
IPAM persistence	the durable allocation rowset + the unique-constraint-violation count (0)	qa-results/int/ipam_<ts>.json
no-log schema	the schemalint report (PASS = zero forbidden tables)	qa-results/int/schemalint_<ts>.txt

The captured rowset/transcript **is** the evidence — the test re-reads it, the Challenge engine ([challenges.md](#)) re-reads it independently. An INT PASS that asserts only "no error returned" without capturing the rowset/transcript is a §11.4.68 absence-of-error bluff and is rejected.

5. Determinism — N-iteration identical evidence

Per §11.4.50 every INT PASS reproduces identically across N=3 (normal) / N=10 (cycle-validation). Container-backed tests are the classic flake source; the mandate is mechanical:

1. **Health-gate, never sleep.** Readiness is `health.WaitReady` against a real probe; a fixed `sleep` is forbidden (the loading-vs-ready confusion §11.4.107(3)).
2. **Fresh infra per run, deterministic seed.** Each `ab_run_n_times` iteration boots a clean Postgres/Redis and seeds identical data, so the captured rowset / transcript hashes identically; a divergent hash is auto-FAIL (no flake escape).
3. **No wall-clock in assertions.** Timing evidence (`publish→delta`) is captured as a value compared to an SLO budget, not asserted equal across runs; the *rowset* and *delta content* are what must hash-match.
4. **Single-resource ownership (§11.4.119).** Parallel INT suites that share an exclusive resource (one edge process, one stream) are partitioned —

exactly one owner drives, others read — so cross-contaminated evidence cannot produce a non-deterministic PASS.

6. Acceptance gate — when INT blocks a release

Gate	Bar	Layer
pre-push hook (§11.4.75 Layer-2)	INT subset GREEN (boots PG+Redis via containers)	local, blocks push
make test INT stage	all INT seams GREEN with captured evidence	release sweep
CM-RLS-ENFORCED	RLS isolation INT PASS + its §1.1 mutation FAILs	pre-build + runtime
schema<code>lint</code> / CM-NO-LOG-SCHEMA	zero durable per-flow tables; backs AC8 (overview §7.2)	pre-build + INT
CM-NO-FAKES-BEYOND-UNIT-TESTS	no mock import in any INT file	pre-build

INT is a release gate for **AC8** (no durable conn/traffic log) and a contributor to **G6** (Phase-0 push-based reconcile, [overview §7.1](#)), **AC2/AC5/AC6** (the control-plane half of reach/reconcile/revoke). An INT seam in FAIL keeps its feature's coverage-ledger cell out of AUTONOMOUS_VERIFIED ([overview §6](#)), blocking the phase release.

7. The paired §1.1 mutation (anti-bluff proof)

The canonical INT mutation — RLS:

```
# §1.1 mutation for CM-RLS-ENFORCED (meta-test plants, asserts FAIL, restores)
- in data-model-ddl migration: ALTER TABLE devices DISABLE ROW LEVEL SECURITY;
- assert: TestRLSCrossTenantDenial now sees device-b1 under tenant-A → test FAILs
- restore (re-enable RLS); assert PASS again (working-tree quiescence §11.4.84)
```

The no-log schema mutation:

```
# §1.1 mutation for CM-NO-LOG-SCHEMA (defeats a "we forgot we log flows" regression)
- seed a forbidden table: CREATE TABLE connections (src_ip inet, dst_ip inet, started_at timestamptz);
```

- assert: schemalint FAILs (a durable per-flow table appeared)
- restore (drop the table); assert schemalint PASS

Each INT gate's mutation makes it FAIL — proving the gate is not a tautology (the §11.4.120 reconciliation rule applies if a *correct* schema change later makes a stale schema-lint rule FAIL: rewrite the rule to the new invariant, never weaken it).

8. Test skeletons

8.1 RLS cross-tenant denial (the canonical INT test)

```
// helix-go/internal/store/rls_integration_test.go
//go:build integration
package store

import (
    "context"; "testing"
    "digital.vasic.containers/pkg/boot"    // §11.4.76 sole
        container seam
    "digital.vasic.containers/pkg/health"
)

func TestRLSCrossTenantDenial(t *testing.T) {
    ctx := context.Background()
    infra, err := boot.Up(ctx, boot.Spec{Postgres: true, Redis:
        true, Rootless: true}) // §11.4.161
    if err != nil { t.Fatalf("boot infra: %v", err) }
    t.Cleanup(func() { _ = infra.Down(ctx) }) //
        §11.4.14 quiescence

    if err := health.WaitReady(ctx, infra, health.Postgres); err !
        = nil { t.Fatal(err) }
    db := mustConnect(t, infra.PostgresDSN())
    migrateProductionDDL(t, db) // real
        RLS policies enabled
    seedTenant(t, db, "tenant-A", "device-a1") //
        through the production store path
    seedTenant(t, db, "tenant-B", "device-b1")

    rows := queryAs(t, db, "tenant-A", `SELECT id FROM
        devices`) // under tenant-A RLS role
    requireContains(t, rows, "device-a1")
    requireNotContains(t, rows, "device-b1") //
        captured rowset = evidence (§11.4.5/.69)
    writeEvidence(t, "qa-results/int/rls", rows) //
        ab_pass_with_evidence cites this
    // paired §1.1 mutation: DISABLE ROW LEVEL SECURITY → this
        test MUST FAIL (CM-RLS-ENFORCED)
}
```


8.2 Enrollment — key-never-leaves-server (§11.4.10 + S2)

```
//go:build integration
func TestEnrollmentPrivateKeyNeverPersistedServerSide(t
    *testing.T) {
    infra := mustBoot(t, boot.Spec{Postgres: true, Rootless:
        true})
    api := startAPI(t, infra) // real
        svc-identity+registry+pk

    tok := mintAnonDeviceToken(t) // real
        token path
    resp := api.Enroll(t, tok,
        devicePubKeyOnly()) // client sends PUBLIC key only
    requireValidMTLSCert(t, resp.Cert) // short-
        lived cert issued (svc-pki)

    // SCAN: no private-key bytes anywhere server-side (DB +
        logs), §11.4.10 / S2
    leaks := scanForPrivateKeyBytes(t, infra.PostgresDSN(),
        infra.LogDir())
    requireEmpty(t, leaks) //
        captured scan report = evidence
    // §1.1 mutation: persist the private key → scan finds it →
        CM-KEY-NEVER-LEAVES FAILS
}
```

8.3 Event backbone round-trip (Redis Streams → coordinator delta)

```
//go:build integration
func TestEventPublishToDeltaEmit(t *testing.T) {
    infra := mustBoot(t, boot.Spec{Postgres: true, Redis: true,
        Rootless: true})
    coord := startCoordinator(t, infra) // real
        consumer group
    bus := connectRedisStreams(t, infra.RedisAddr())

    bus.Publish(t, "device.enrolled", enrollEvent("carol",
        "10.0.0.3"))
    delta := coord.AwaitDelta(t, 1*time.Second) // SL01
        budget < 1 s
    requireDeltaAdds(t, delta, "carol") //
        minimal delta, captured transcript
    requirePolicyFiltered(t, delta, forPeer("alice")) // need-
        to-know peer filtering
    // §1.1 mutation: drop the XADD ack path → delta never emitted
        → test FAILS
}
```

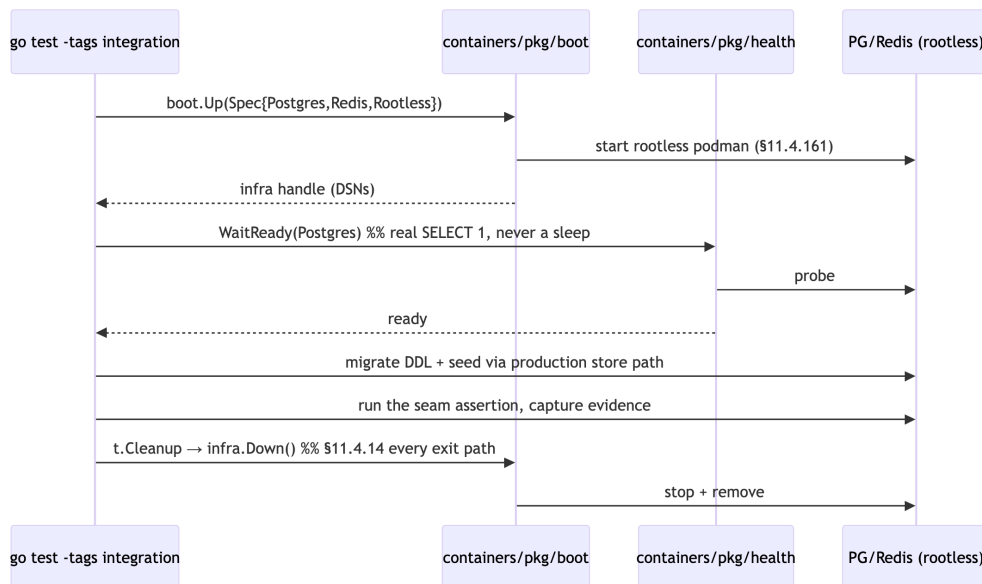
8.4 No-log schema invariant (DDL + schema-lint)

```
-- the invariant schemalint enforces against the LIVE booted DB
    (AC8)
-- ALLOWED: aggregate counters only
CREATE TABLE traffic_counters (
    tenant_id    uuid NOT NULL,
    window_start timestampz NOT NULL,
    rx_bytes     bigint NOT NULL,          -- SUM over window, NOT
        per-connection
    tx_bytes     bigint NOT NULL,
    PRIMARY KEY (tenant_id, window_start)
);
-- FORBIDDEN (the §1.1 mutation seeds this → schemalint MUST
    FAIL):
-- CREATE TABLE connections (src_ip inet, dst_ip inet, started_at
    timestampz, ...);

# scripts/schemalint.sh – runs against the containers-booted DB,
    NOT a static file
psql "$INT_DSN" -Atc "
    SELECT table_name FROM information_schema.columns
    WHERE column_name IN
        ('src_ip','dst_ip','src_port','dst_port','packet','flow_id')
    AND table_schema='public' | grep -q . \
&& ab_fail "no-log invariant breached: a per-flow column
    exists" \
|| ab_pass_with_evidence "no durable conn/traffic log" "qa-
    results/int/schemalint_$(date +%s).txt"
```

8a. The on-demand-infra lifecycle (failure modes + cleanup)

The §11.4.76 on-demand-infra invariant has a precise lifecycle whose failure modes are all defects, never flakes:



Failure mode	Symptom	Classification
boot times out	<code>boot.Up</code> returns error	infra/host defect — surfaced, not a test FAIL bluff (§11.4.1)
<code>WaitReady</code> replaced by sleep	intermittent "connection refused"	a §11.4.107(3) loading-vs-ready bug → fix the harness, never retry-hope (§11.4.102)
<code>infra.Down</code> skipped	orphan container survives	§11.4.14 violation; post-test sanity check FAILs the run
rootful spec on a rootless platform	boot rejected	§11.4.161 — the spec must be <code>Rootless:true</code>
a needed primitive missing from containers	can't boot the edge	extend upstream (§11.4.74), never a raw podman workaround

8b. Evidence-shape contract per seam (the §11.4.69 binding)

The INT layer's anti-bluff guarantee is that **the captured artifact's shape is fixed per seam** — a PASS that does not produce the fixed shape is rejected at the gate, not merely flagged:

Seam	Required shape	A bluff that the shape rejects
RLS	a JSON rowset with tenant-A's rows and without tenant-B's	"query returned no error" (B2) — no rowset means no proof

Seam	Required shape	A bluff that the shape rejects
enrollment	issued cert chain + an empty private-key scan report	"enrollment succeeded" (B1) — no scan means the key could have leaked
events	a consumed-event + emitted-delta transcript with timing	"delta emitted" claim with no transcript (B3 wrong-plane)
no-log schema	the live-DB introspection report (zero forbidden columns)	a static-DDL grep (misses a runtime migration, §11.4.108)

9. Open decisions surfaced for QA

#	Decision	Options	Recommendation
I-D1	Fresh-infra-per-test vs shared-infra-per-suite	clean boot each test (slow, deterministic) vs one boot per package (fast)	clean boot per test for the security floor (RLS, enrollment); shared per-package for read-only seams — balances §11.4.50 determinism against §11.4.82 iteration speed
I-D2	schema-lint timing	static-DDL grep vs live-DB introspection	live-DB introspection (overview §5.2) — a static grep misses a migration that adds a forbidden table at runtime (the SOURCE→ARTIFACT gap, §11.4.108)
I-D3	edge-in-INT vs edge-only-in-E2E	boot edge for policy-config INT vs defer all edge to E2E	boot edge for config-reach INT, defer packet-enforce to E2E — keeps the INT/E2E boundary at "packet on a wire"

UNVERIFIED: the exact `boot.Spec` field names (`Postgres`, `Redis`, `Rootless`, `Edge`) and `health.WaitReady` signature are the **intended** `containers` submodule API per the overview skeleton; confirm against the pinned `digital.vasic.containers` SHA at integration time (§11.4.74 — extend upstream if absent).

Sources verified

- Volume-8 overview §2 (taxonomy row INT), §5.2 (the containers-submodule skeleton + no-log DDL), §6 (coverage ledger), §9 (Makefile test: + rootless note) — read 2026-06-26.
- Sibling specs cross-referenced: ../v03-control-plane/data-model-ddl.md, ../v03-control-plane/svc-identity.md, ../v03-control-plane/svc-pki.md, ../v03-control-plane/svc-events.md, ../v03-control-plane/svc-coordinator.md, ../v03-control-plane/svc-ipam.md, ../v05-security/no-logging-as-code.md, ../v05-security/identity-and-enrollment.md — filenames confirmed present 2026-06-26.
- Constitution: §11.4.27 (no-fakes-beyond-unit), §11.4.76 (containers-submodule sole path), §11.4.161 (rootless), §11.4.74 (extend-upstream), §11.4.14 (quiescence cleanup), §11.4.5/.68/.69 (captured / no-absence-of-error / sink-side evidence), §11.4.50 (determinism), §11.4.107(3) (loading-vs-ready), §11.4.108 (SOURCE→ARTIFACT gap), §11.4.119 (single-resource owner), §11.4.120 (gate reconciliation), §11.4.10 (credentials), §1.1 (paired mutation) — from CLAUDE.md in-context.
- The containers submodule API (pkg/boot/pkg/health/pkg/compose) is taken from the overview skeleton — **not independently fetched from vasic-digital/containers** (UNVERIFIED; confirm at the pinned SHA).